MCP

Title:

Babe

Author:

Steve DuBois

© 2024 Steve DuBois
Publication Date: August 15, 2024

Published by

MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS

An imprint of Rainbow Skull LLC

Made in the USA

Permission for performance of this piece is granted for the purpose of performance in competition by middle school, high school, and undergraduate collegiate performers. Online, remote, and video performances are permitted for these purposes only. Video or audio recordings of performances may not be shared or posted online without permission from the publisher. Theatrical performance and all other kinds of public performance, whether broadcast, online, or on stage, are prohibited without prior written permission from Mushroom Cloud Press, an imprint of Rainbow Skull LLC.

This script is authorized for competition only if the competitor or the competitor's representative, including but not limited to parent or educational entity, has purchased a copy of the script from Mushroom Cloud Press or an authorized retailer. The script must be presented with the cover sheet bearing the ISBN. Additional requirements for performance may be made by tournament and league rules.

Tournament officials: please contact Mushroom Cloud Press to validate script purchase.

For all inquiries and to see our full catalog of scripts, visit

MushroomCloudPress.com

[1928. A seedy living room in a row house in Watertown, Massachusetts. HELEN WOODRUFF RUTH lives here. She is fine-featured, thirty-one years old, but looks significantly older. Her figure is willowy, her auburn hair shot with grey. Within a month, she will be dead in a house fire, the circumstances of which will never be fully explained or adequately investigated. One month after that, her former husband will re-marry.]

HELEN: Welcome to my home. Well, not my home, technically…but never mind that, for now. It's not the house you're here about. It's about…him, of course. George. My husband.

I might be the last person in America who still calls him "George". Do you know how he got that nickname of his? It was because he could never remember anyone's name. Not even his teammates. No, with George, it was always, "Hey, babe, ya see what I did ta that pitch?" Or, "Hey, babe, we goin' out on the town tonight?" Everyone was "babe" to him. And so, eventually, he was "Babe" to everyone. George Herman "Babe" Ruth.

[A long pause.]

I was sixteen years old, on my own, new to Boston and without a clue as to how to live there. And I'm waitressing at Landers' Coffee Shop, and one morning, there he is. This solitary figure, bulldog face and shoulders like a plough horse, demolishing his third stack of pancakes, and demanding more, in a voice as loud and insistent as Gabriel's trumpet. And as I hustle them over to him, he looks up, and our eyes meet.

You should understand, he looked very, very different then. I mean, how was it that that ballplayer described George the other day? "A beer keg on stilts?" Accurate enough. Lord knows he's got enough alcohol in him. But back then, nineteen-year-old George…he was this lean, athletic *demigod*. I mean, he used to steal bases, can you believe it? That was how the World Series ended, one year…he was standing on first base, in the ninth inning. And he looked down the line to second and saw something he wanted. And he went for it, and they threw him out by ten feet. And he destroyed everything that the people around him had been working for. But George wanted that base. And what George wanted, George went after.

And that day, at Landers' Coffee Shop, what he wanted was *me*. Oh, God, how to describe it? He wasn't yet the most famous man in America, but even then, he just…he had this *gravity*, you know? Like, to be around him was to be sucked into his orbit. When he was in the room, everything else faded into the background. You couldn't look at anything but him. And it was *me* he wanted. *Me!* And…do you see, everyone else was "babe", *but I was Helen*. My name was worth knowing!

It was madness. We were *children*. We courted for a grand total of three months. And we hadn't been married a year before the whole world discovered him.

Now. I'd showed George what it was to be intimate with a woman. And here's what you must understand about George: when George decides he loves a thing, he can't set it aside. If it's in

front of him, he will take it, and devour it, like those pancakes. And he'll demand seconds. Thirds. Fourths.

And then we went to New York. And George and New York…matches and gasoline.

[A long pause]

We'd wanted a family. And twice, we managed to get me…but I…I lost them, you see. And George didn't *blame* me, exactly. But he was heartbroken.

And then one day, he comes to me, and he can't meet my eye. Helen, he says, I screwed up. But it can work out for us. We can make it a good thing.

Her name was Juanita. The woman, I mean. The newborn baby girl we adopted from her, the one we told the press I'd given birth to, we named Dorothy. Even then, she had his features. She's six now, and she looks more like him every day. *[pause]* Poor thing.

And being a father, you'd think it would change a man. With George, it just turned up the volume. He became…himself, only more so. His lust for life…his lust for *everything*. He had the total adoration of *two* women now. So why stop there?

And that…*that,* you see…was the hell of it. The pure undiluted *hell* of it. That I never, ever stopped feeling about him the way I did that morning in Landers' coffee shop. And I sat home, caring for our…caring for *his* daughter. Reading about his…*exploits*. And all that time, I was praying, *praying to Jesus*, that I'd somehow be *enough* for him again! That he would stop seeing the women in front of him and recognize the woman behind him! *That he could for one goddamn instant stop falling in love with every goddamn thing he saw!*

And then…I came down with this…condition. And it turned out I'd picked it up from him, and he'd picked it up from…some chorus girl, I suppose. And I spent close to a month in St. Vincents, having the symptoms treated. And after I'm discharged, George comes to me. And he tells me, look. It's been great, between us. But it's not working out. We need some time apart.

And I ask him, what's her name.

And he stares at the floor. And he tells me, "Her name's Claire, babe."

Claire's no sixteen-year-old. Very much a woman grown. A sophisticated woman, who can put his affair–*all* his affairs–in order. George wanted to divorce me and marry her. So I set my terms: I wanted one hundred thousand dollars to take care of Dorothy and myself. And do you know what? I finally discovered something Babe Ruth didn't love.

It's all gone now. I think I mentioned, this home…it's not mine. He's been generous. He's given me a place to stay. He's even let me borrow his name. I'm going by Helen Kinder at the

moment. It's for the best. Helen Ruth…that's not a name anyone wants to hear these days. My home, my prospects…even my name. Gone. Disappeared over the fence like some pitcher's feeble fastball.

But I've still got that…condition. That's George's enduring gift to me, the final sign of his love.

[A long pause]

I told you about George's…gravity. The way he has. How we all end up in his orbit. When you're with him for long enough, I suppose, you end up becoming him.

I drink now, for one thing. Not as much as George, but who could? And…well…here I am, in this house, right? A married woman, shacking up with a man who isn't my husband. What if the papers found out? Imagine the scandal.

And there's this, too. Remember what I told you about how George could never be bothered to learn anyone's name? It occurs to me…after all this time we've spent here chatting…I never did bother to ask for yours.

Thanks for listening…babe.